



THE IDEA OF JUSTICE
by AMARTYA SEN
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| By S. Prasannarajan |

Justice is a word that continues to power the idealism of the best and worst of mankind. Philosophers and prophets, kings and revolutionaries, presidents and pamphleteers, politicians and proselytisers—you name them and they all have been under the spell of the word. Justice: it's what minds like Immanuel Kant and Jean-Jacques Rousseau illuminated in their treatises; what Ashoka and Gandhi, in varying ways, exemplified in their lives; what Marx theorised at length and Stalin used to build the Gulag; what led Hitler to the Final Solution; and what drove the neo-Conservative freedom-exporters to Mission Mesopotamia. It's what works behind the italicised anger of a pulp intellectual like Arundhati Roy. It's what keeps Prakash Karat marginally relevant in spite of being an archival curiosity and what sends the desperate Hindu nationalist to the vandalised sites of mythology. Justice, in theory, is an argument against grievance; justice, in practice, not necessarily results in happiness. It is almost always accompanied by resentment. A just society. A just war. Heaven on earth. You could go on listing the catchphrases of the Utopians and geopolitical moralists who are irredeemably entrapped by the concepts of fairness. It takes the intervention of one of the most socially engaged

Sen and a Sense OF JUSTICE

The most prolific philosopher of our time challenges the notions of fairness and offers an alternative

philosophers of our time to redeem the idea of justice from the misplaced idealism of its interpreters.

Still, it should be said: *The Idea of Justice* is not Amartya Sen's handbook for those in power or for other practitioners of fairness and justness. (One reason is that there are not many among them who are literate enough to follow his cross-cultural arguments and lively digressions.) Liberally sprinkled with footnotes, this book is the Nobel laureate's rejoinder—never arrogant but always graceful in acknowledging his indebtedness to the subjects of his critique—to the theories of justice that speaks little about how to



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